

Topic Input – Gender



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

In this week we will look at the issue of gender norms, roles & stereotypes within the context of feminism & gender quality.



Task 1: Discuss the following in pairs/small groups:

- What do you understand by the term 'gender equality'?
- What do you understand by the word 'Feminism'? Is it the same?
- Would you describe yourself as a 'Feminist'? Why/why not?
- Which factors do you think would influence whether or not someone would identify as feminist?
- Are you aware of any examples of mainstream feminism/gender equality in your country, or the world in general?

Task 2: Look at the word document for an article about why ‘feminism’ doesn’t seem to be a popular term.

We are going to read actively – this means you should not only take notes, but also try to note down questions of the text. This is good practise for your Academic Interaction class.

e.g. Line one says: *“In recent years, feminist movements have attracted significant attention **in Europe and North America**”*.

A relevant question to note would be “what about other continents/countries?”

Reading



Task 3: Compare your notes and your questions with your classmates. Your teacher will ask you to share some ideas you had



Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 5: "A 2018 YouGov poll found that 34% of women in the UK said "yes" when asked whether they were a feminist, up from 27% in 2013. It's a similar picture in Europe, with fewer than half of men and women polled in five countries agreeing they were a feminist. This ranged from 8% of respondents in Germany, to 40% in Sweden."

- UK: 27%, Germany: 8%, Sweden: 40% - why could it be so varied?

Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 7: "And in a 2017 UK poll, 8% said they agreed with traditional gender roles - that a man should earn money and a woman should stay at home - down from 43% in 1984."

- What do you think has caused the change of opinion over the last 30 years?

Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 8 & 10: "It could be that they [people] do not feel the term speaks to them. The term feminist is less likely to appeal to working-class women, polls suggest... lower income groups support the principle behind feminism, but aren't keen on the word itself."

P. 9: "Almost one in three ...[of]...those in managerial, administrative and professional occupations called themselves a feminist in a 2018 poll. This compared with one in five from grades C2DE...manual workers, state pensioners, casual workers, and the unemployed. But those from lower income backgrounds are just as likely to support equal rights."

- What do you think is the link between success/income/class and feminism?

Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 13: "I found associations of the term "feminism" with man-hating, lesbianism or lack of femininity was a key factor in rejections of the label "feminist". The majority said they did not want to call themselves feminist because they feared they would be associated with these traits."

- Are these stereotypes the same in your country?
- How do you think these started? Who was responsible?

Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 14 & 15: "...[H]ow could the image of feminism be improved? Arguably, as a society we should do more to challenge narrowly defined expectations of how women should look and act. Working harder to make this movement more inclusive could mean that feminism speaks to the experiences and concerns of diverse groups of women."

- What do you think some worthy goals of modern-day feminists could be?

Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 3 & 4: "Half a million responded in the first 24 hours and the hashtag has been used in more than 80 countries...Many other celebrities have publicly embraced feminism..."

- Is the link between success and Feminism exemplified with celebrities?
- How helpful is celebrity endorsement? Do they mean it, or are they just self-promoting?

Task 4: Try to come up with some explanations/ideas regarding the following; at this stage, we don't need definite answers, but it's important to explore the questions that have been raised:

P. 11: "[In the USA] 12% of Hispanic women, 21% of African American women, 23% of Asian women and 26% of white women identify as a feminist. Three-quarters of all the women polled said the feminist movement has done either "a lot" or "some" to improve the lives of white women. However, just 60% said it had achieved much for women of other ethnicities - a sentiment shared by 46% of African American women."

- The respondents are different races, but the same nationality: can you think of reasons why feminism would only (seem) to support white women?
- Why would the number of Hispanic women who identify as feminists be almost 50% lower than other groups?

Task 5: In small groups, discuss the following questions – if possible, try to work with some classmates from another country.

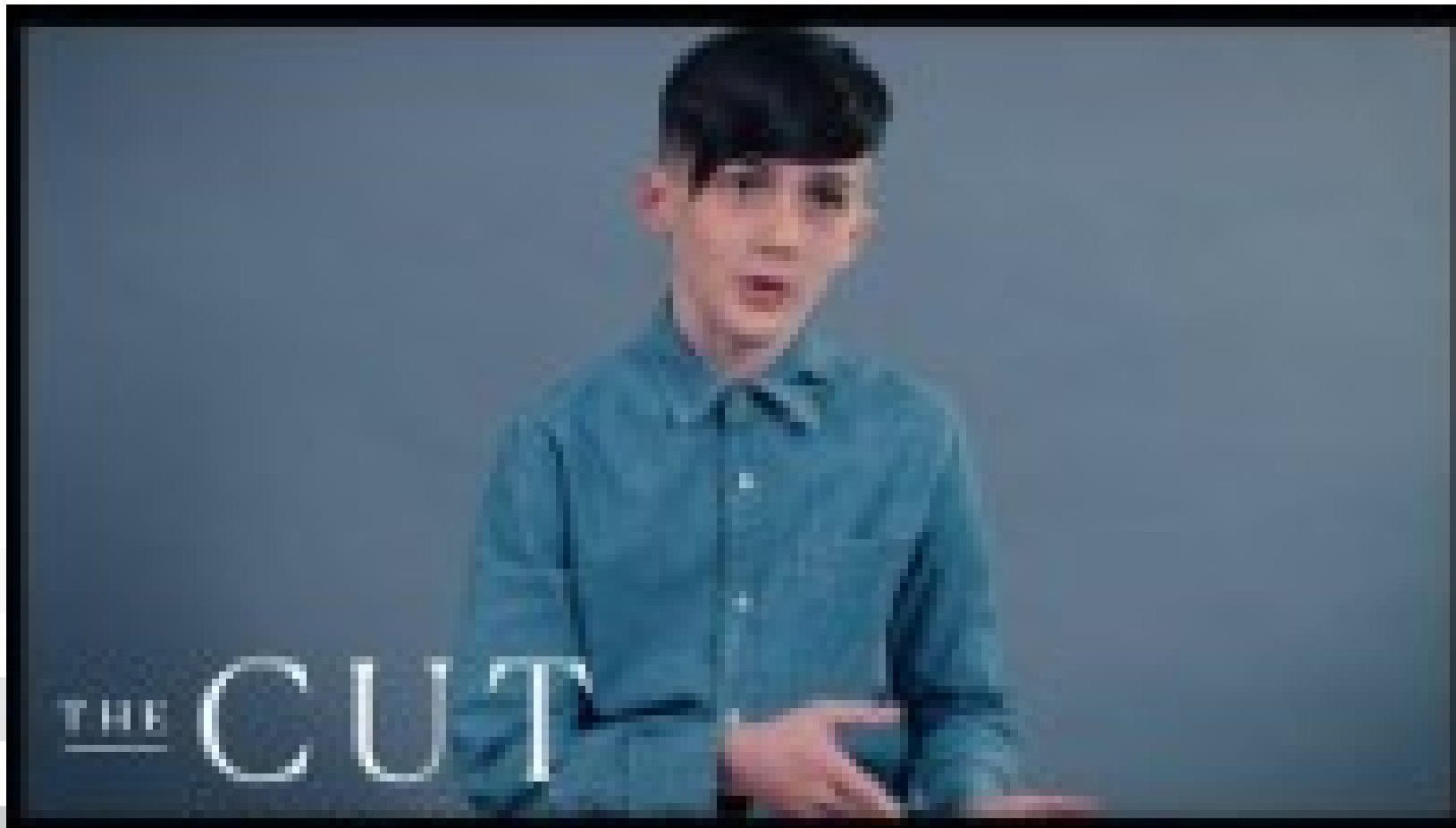
You could compare these to your parents' generation, but in your experience:

- What are some attributes expected of girls/women? And of boys/men?
- How are they expected to behave? What is encouraged, or avoided?
- How are they expected to look?
- What hobbies do they have (generally speaking)?
- Who is more likely to take on the role of managing the family and/or the home?
- What toys do young girls and boys play with?
- If you go out on a date with someone, who pays?

Listening



Task 6: Watch this brief 2018 video of some American children talking about gender stereotypes. Are they in agreement with what you've just discussed?



Task 6: Gender norms, how men and women are ‘expected to behave’, are instilled at a very young age and can have profound consequences. How do you think they affect:

- Men and women’s attitudes and behaviour
 - Mental health
 - Society
 - Gender equality
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